Taking time, breaking codes

White teachers exploring race, racism, and identity

COLLEGE OF EDUCATION
+ HUMAN DEVELOPMENT

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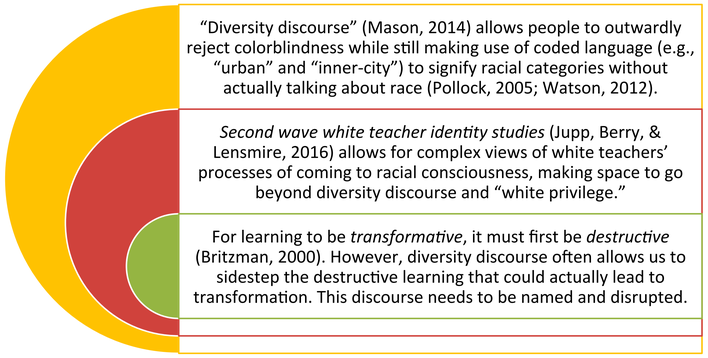
Context

Abstract

Exploring the often fitful and always unfinished process of U.S. white preservice teachers' coming to racial consciousness, this paper addresses moments of clarity and moments of frustration as that clarity fades. These moments are positioned in the context of the ongoing "complicated conversations" that occur when teacher educators are able to cultivate authentic, sustained relationships with undergraduate preservice teachers. I also examine external factors that serve as catalysts to–or informants of–students' moments of growth as racially conscious people. This work contributes to understandings of how preservice teachers can learn about racial identity in ways that benefit individual teachers and support their work in schools and communities. These findings buttress previous work in "second wave" white teacher identity research and can translate directly into teacher education course and program design.

This work calls out the system of white supremacy that makes it difficult for students–and others–to "locate themselves" in order to work toward social justice. By calling out that system, we can inch closer to both systemic and individual approaches to transforming it.

Central assumptions



Data generation and analysis

- Connected to a larger ethnographic study on how preservice teachers come to understand themselves as racialized people learning and working in racist institutions.
- The research site was a regional comprehensive university in the Midwest where I worked as a professor of Multicultural Education.
- Purposive sample of three students who each demonstrate a unique trajectory toward racial consciousness, none of whom represents the trajectory implied in common one-shot approaches to preparing students to understand the social and cultural contexts of education. To varying degrees and at different points in the process, each of these young women was willing and able to join in a complicated conversation about race, racism, identity, and schooling.
- Data generated included student writing in two courses (Foundations of multicultural education and School and society) and formal and informal interviews. Data were analyzed through grounded theory (Merriam, 2009; Strauss & Corbin, 1990).

Focal student

Jen

Jen failed the *Foundations of Multicultural Education* course twice; once with me, and once with a previous faculty member. She had also failed another course in the major, and all of the disciplinary and dispositional mechanisms at the program's disposal had been deployed, short of exiting her from the program.

The most remarkable thing about my two-year relationship with Jen came in its final moment. After she completed the requirements for the special independent study version of *Foundations of Multicultural Education* that we had agreed upon to help her pass the course, we met at a suburban coffee shop near her summer job.
As we packed up to leave, I asked Jen if she would be willing to talk for another few minutes about her progress through the foundations courses in teacher education. I acknowledged that I had never had an experience with a student quite like I had had with her, and that I wanted to learn from it. When she agreed to continue talking, I told Jen that I had noticed a distinct "moment" in her writing that summer when things seemed to change. In her "self study essay," Jen wrote about an interaction with an African immigrant parent at the summer parks program at which she was an assistant teacher. This interaction had occurred the previous summer, and had plagued Jen ever since. She wrote about it in a journal entry in Summer 2013, at the time with an attitude of overt racism and linguicism: Jen and this parent had clashed over some small detail about her child's behavior at the summer program, and Jen had attributed both the disagreement and their subsequent communication difficulties to the parent's lack of understanding of the "American" way of doing things. Jen had chosen to reexamine the same interaction for her self study essay in Summer 2014, this time treating the issue with a considerable amount of care and consideration for how her lens and attitude had shaped the experience and its outcomes.

Jen told me that she had noticed the change, too. When I asked what she thought may have contributed to it, her verbal response was simple: she said, "I wasn't ready (before) for what you needed to teach me" (Interview, 7/25/2014). When I asked what she thought had made the difference, Jen told me that she had needed time and space to really consider the questions I was asking through the course, and that it had helped to take away the pressure of needing to perform her learning process in the classroom with her peers. On the reflective cover sheet that opened her Self Study Writing Portfolio assignment, she reinforced these insights with the following concluding sentence:

"I have had the opportunity to ask myself difficult questions to show vulnerability in a profession that preaches perfection."

Jen took time to come to a place where she could articulate that vulnerability, and she aptly described it as a contradiction to do so in the teaching field, where she has grown to feel she is expected to demonstrate some form of "perfection" at all times. Britzman's writing often reminds us that teacher education must be a process of taking time with difficult questions. I never would have predicted that this particular student would be the one who could make Britzman's question so real to me:

"If teacher education could begin to reclaim difficult knowledge, what would be the work of teacher educators" (Britzman, 2000, p. 201)?

Implications

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When time is set aside for teacher education students to genuinely and deeply engage with their racialized selves in relationships with schools and society, transformations occur. The students learn about themselves and about society, and together we may unlock the potential for these students to break through the codes of diversity discourse (Mason, 2014). These findings have implications for scholars and practitioners of teacher education who have worked for decades to find meaningful ways to build sociopolitical consciousness among predominately white preservice teachers. This helps to push toward deeper understandings of how today's preservice teachers are conceiving of white racial identities and their own potential roles in our work toward justice in schools and beyond.

These findings also illustrate the futility of studying any educative setting–my university classroom or elsewhere–in isolation. Students of all ages bring their real and figured worlds into classrooms (Holland, et al., 1998). Strong teachers learn to read those worlds with their students (Janks, 2013; 2014). But what happens when you have Sabrina, Sam, and Jen in the same room at the same time, plus 27 other students? We must pursue additional work in research settings and also advocacy in teacher preparation programs to create sanctioned spaces for the kind of relationships built on complicated conversation that I have described here. Simultaneously, we absolutely need to consider alternative spaces where white people might be asked to consider their racialized locations in U.S. society without doing so at the expense of their classmates, colleagues, and/or students of color.

Ongoing questions

- What are the costs of engaging at this level with white preservice teachers? What are the costs of NOT engaging at this level? For their classmates and colleagues who are of color? For colleges of teacher education? For children in schools? For society as a whole? **What can we afford?**

- What does it look like when we envision teacher education that acknolwedges and eng*ages with the* damage we are doing to children? That approaches learning through complicated conversation (Pinar, 2011)?

Selected references

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